Visitor Guide to the Isle of Carran

2026 edition. The Isle of Carran is a fictional island invented for this sample document; all places, prices and timetables are made up.

1. Welcome

The Isle of Carran lies 28 km off the west coast of the mainland and is about 40 km long and 15 km wide. Around 6,200 people live on the island, half of them in the harbour town of **Portneath**. Carran is known for its sea cliffs, its puffin colony, white sand beaches on the western shore and a small whisky distillery that has operated since 1832.

The island has a mild, wet climate. Summer (June to August) averages 18 C during the day; winter averages 7 C. Rain is possible in any month, and wind is common on the western cliffs. Pack layers and a waterproof jacket whatever the season.

2. Getting There

2.1 Ferry

Carran Ferries runs car and passenger ferries from **Kellport** on the mainland to Portneath. The crossing takes **1 hour 50 minutes**.

Season	Departures from Kellport	Departures from Portneath
Summer (May 15 to Sep 30)	07:00, 11:30, 16:00, 19:30	09:15, 13:45, 18:00
Winter (Oct 1 to May 14)	08:00, 15:00	10:30, 17:15

Fare (single)	Price
Adult foot passenger	14.50
Child (5 to 15), under 5 free	7.25
Car under 5 m, driver included	62.00
Bicycle	3.00

Car spaces sell out in July and August; book at least four weeks ahead. Foot passengers do not need to book. Sailings may be cancelled in winds above force 8, so allow a spare day before onward travel.

2.2 Air

A small airstrip at Ballan, 6 km north of Portneath, has two flights a day from the mainland city of Dunmore on weekdays and one on Saturdays. The flight takes 35 minutes on a 19-seat aircraft. Baggage is limited to 15 kg per person.

3. Getting Around

The island bus route **C1** runs a loop from Portneath around the island every two hours from 08:00 to 18:00 in summer (four times a day in winter). A day ticket costs 6.00. Bicycles can be hired at Carran Cycles on Harbour Street from 18.00 per day, including e-bikes from 35.00 per day. Roads outside Portneath are mostly single-track with passing places; pull in to let oncoming traffic pass and never park in a passing place.

4. Things to See and Do

4.1 Hallin Head and the puffin colony

The cliffs at Hallin Head on the north-west tip of the island are home to about **3,000 pairs of Atlantic puffins** from late April to early August. A marked 4 km path leads from the car park to the viewing points. Stay behind the rope line: the cliff edge is unstable, and puffins nest in burrows that collapse easily. Dogs must be on a lead from April to August.

4.2 Beaches

- **Traigh Bhan** (west coast): 2 km of white sand, the island's most popular beach. Lifeguards on duty 11:00 to 17:00 in July and August.
- **Camas Beag** (south): sheltered cove, good for families and paddleboarding. Paddleboard hire 25.00 for two hours.
- **Rubha Dubh** (east): rocky shore with rock pools at low tide. Not suitable for swimming because of strong currents.

4.3 Carran Distillery

Founded in 1832 and still using its original copper stills. Tours run daily at 11:00, 13:00 and 15:00 from March to October (Tuesday to Saturday at 13:00 in winter). The standard tour takes 1 hour and costs 15.00, including two tastings; the warehouse tour costs 40.00. Visitors under 18 are welcome on tours but may not taste. Book ahead in summer.

4.4 Carran Heritage Centre

Located in the old schoolhouse in Portneath, the Heritage Centre covers the island's history from Bronze Age settlement through the 19th-century herring boom to the present. Open 10:00 to 17:00, Monday to Saturday, April to October. Entry 6.00 for adults, children free.

4.5 Ben Carran

The island's highest point is **Ben Carran (512 m)**. The path from Glenmore Farm is 9 km return and takes 3 to 4 hours. The upper section is steep and can be in cloud; take a map and compass, and check the weather forecast before setting out.

5. Where to Stay

Name	Type	Location	Price per night (double)
The Harbour Hotel	Hotel, 22 rooms	Portneath	145 to 210
Sealight Guest House	Bed and breakfast, 6 rooms	Portneath	95 to 120
Traigh Bhan Campsite	Tents and campervans	West coast	12 per person; electric hook-up 8
Glenmore Bothy	Basic shelter, no facilities	Below Ben Carran	Free, first come first served
Hallin Cottages	Self-catering, 4 cottages	North	650 to 980 per week (Saturday changeover)

Wild camping is permitted away from roads and houses, for no more than two nights in one place. Take all litter home and do not light fires on peat ground.

6. Food and Drink

- **The Creel** (Harbour Street): seafood restaurant serving local langoustines and scallops. Open for dinner Wednesday to Sunday; booking essential in summer.
- **Morag's Kitchen**: cafe with home baking and soup; open daily 09:00 to 16:00.
- **The Anchor Inn**: the island's oldest pub, with live folk music on Friday nights.
- **Portneath Co-op**: the only large grocery shop, open 08:00 to 20:00 daily (10:00 to 17:00 on Sundays in winter).

7. Events

- **Carran Puffin Festival**, second weekend of June: guided walks, boat trips and a photography competition.
- **Portneath Regatta**, first Saturday of August: sailing and rowing races in the harbour.
- **Carran Whisky Weekend**, last weekend of September: tastings and distillery open days.

8. Practical Information

- The only cash machine is in the Co-op in Portneath. Most businesses accept cards, but carry some cash for the bus and honesty boxes at car parks.
- Mobile coverage is good in Portneath but patchy elsewhere, especially on the west coast.
- **Medical care:** Portneath Health Centre, open weekdays 08:30 to 18:00. For emergencies call the national emergency number; serious cases are transferred to the mainland by air ambulance.
- Fuel is available only at the Portneath filling station, closed on Sundays. Fill up before exploring.
- Visitor Information Centre: Pier Road, Portneath, open daily 09:00 to 17:00 from April to October.